
THE MONKEY AND THE TURTLE

A classic Philippine fable retold in a single breath

Once, a clever turtle and a greedy monkey found a banana tree floating down a Philippine river and decided to split it, with the monkey greedily claiming the upper half with leaves thinking it would grow faster, leaving the turtle with the seemingly lifeless roots. While the monkey's half quickly withered and died, the turtle's roots flourished into a magnificent tree laden with ripe, golden fruit. Unable to climb to harvest his bounty, the turtle struck a deal with the monkey to gather the bananas, but the selfish monkey climbed up and stayed in the branches, devouring every single fruit himself while mocking his friend below. In clever retaliation, the turtle lined the tree trunk with sharp thorns, so that when the bloated monkey finally slid down, he was badly pricked and vowed revenge—only to be outsmarted one last time when the turtle tricked him into throwing him into the river, where the turtle safely swam away, proving for generations that humility and wit will always triumph over greed.
